Putter Delight

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Won silver at the 2022 Hangzhou Asian Games; narrowly missed a medal at the Tokyo Olympics (2021)

GOLF IS ANYTHING BUT boring for Aditi Ashok. Hearing her talk about her passion of two decades, it seems profound. She observes how golf "sometimes doesn't make sense". "The ball is never going to be exactly where it was yesterday." How forces of nature are one's real opponents. How she enjoys the solitude that comes with the game. How an aggressive temperament isn't part of its behavioural code. "It is just you against the golf course," says Aditi. "You have to be patient and can never let your mind drift to what's going to happen. Just when you think you've done something right, the game puts you down."

She may as well be analysing her performance at the recent Hangzhou Asian Games where, after scoring a career-lowest round of 61 on day three, she was a firm favourite for gold—only to lose it in the last few holes on the final day. Nonetheless, she became the first Indian woman to win a medal in golf. Aditi has been excelling since her inspiring run at the Tokyo Olympics. This year, she has won two LET (Ladies European Tour) titles and had five top 10 finishes on the LPGA tour.

Golf is a family affair in the Ashok household. Aditi's father, who is in real estate, is her caddy for most tournaments, while her mother, a former HR professional and radio jockey, is her manager. "It helps to have someone you know well while you play," she says.

Aditi was only five and a half years old when she held a putter for the first time at the Karnataka Golf Association in Bengaluru. She grew up following PGA tournaments on TV late into the night. "I knew about women golfers but never saw them play...to see how the women's game differs from the men's," she says. The sport continues to be an expensive pursuit in India and also restricted given that most courses are either under the army or privately owned. It doesn't help that there aren't that many courses around. Ask Aditi how golf could get better, and her answer is simple: "Allow kids to play more on the course." ■

–Suhani Singh

WORK RULES

"Working hard is important but make sure you have fun while doing it. Don't do it because someone else wants you to"

FAVOURITE GREEN
Bangalore Golf Club, one of the oldest golf courses in India



Aditi Ashok, *25*
India's highest-ranked woman golfer at No. 42

AFP